Stony Brook Institute at Anhui University

安徽大学纽约石溪学院

YJ40211 Legal, Social and Ethical Issues in Information Systems (SBU's ISE 312) Course Information

Spring 2026

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Course Description

- This course deals with the impact of computers on us as individuals and on our society. Rapid changes in computing technology and in our use of that technology have changed the way we work, play, and interact with other people. These changes have created a flood of new social and legal issues that demand critical examination. For example, technologies such as Gmail, Facebook, along with music sharing sites and wikis create new social, ethical, and legal issues

Course Description

- In short:
  - Issues that arise from computing technology, the Internet, and other aspects of cyberspace.
    - To understand the implications and impacts of the technology.
  - Historical background to put some of today's issues in context and perspective.
  - Ethical issues for computer professionals
    - not different from ethical principles in other professions or other aspects of life: honesty, responsibility, and fairness.
    - but special kinds of problems arise in our profession, so we will discuss professional ethical guidelines and case scenarios specific to computing professions.

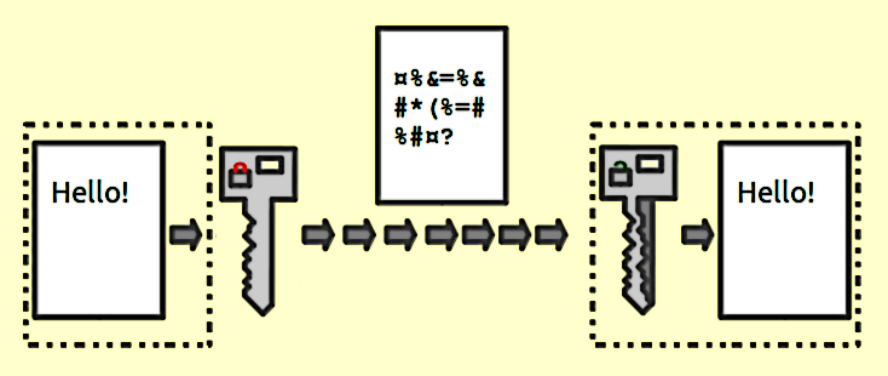
Course Description

- Here are a few examples of the issues we will be talking about:
  - There is a great deal of information about all of us recorded in computer databases.
    - What rules should govern how this information is used?
  - We all get privacy notices in fine print from our banks, credit card companies, etc.
    - What do they really mean?

There are (at least) two sides to almost all of the questions we will consider in this course. We will spend much of our class time discussing the issues and exploring different points of view.

Course Description

- Hacking, identity theft and credit card fraud has increased in recent years.
  - What are responses to these types of fraud and what precautions can we take to prevent this from happening?
- New encryption methods make it possible to keep e-mail and phone conversations secret from others.
  - How should our desire for privacy be balanced with the need of law-enforcement agencies to intercept communications of suspected criminals or terrorists?



Course Description

- More examples:
  - How serious are the problems created by Web sites that contain pornography, "hate" material directed at various groups, bomb-making information, etc?
    - Should there be any restrictions on material that is put on the Web?
  - Computers are increasingly used to control medical devices, airplanes and other safety-critical systems.
    - How safe are such systems?
    - How safe is “safe enough”?
    - What can we do to manage the risks involved?

Course Description

- More examples:
  - It is easy to use computers to copy music, software, books, etc., in violation of copyright law.
    - What is the extent of this problem?
    - How do ethical principles impact behavior in terms of access to material under copyright protection?
    - What can or should be done about it?
    - What is free software?
    - Should all software be free?

Official Course Outcomes

- The following are the official course goals agreed upon by the faculty for this course:
  - An understanding of how computing and information systems give rise to social issues and ethical dilemmas.
  - An ability to discuss the benefits offered by computing technology in many different areas and the risks and problems associated with these technologies.
  - An understanding of some social, legal, philosophical, political, constitutional, and economical issues related to computers and the historical background of these issues.
  - To recognize the need for continuing professional development.

Topics

- **Major Topics Covered in Course:**
  - Privacy
  - Freedom of speech
  - Intellectual property
  - Crime
  - Impact on work environment
  - Evaluating and controlling technology
  - Errors, failures, and risk
  - Professional ethics and responsibilities

Textbook

- A Gift of Fire, 4th Edition, Sara Baase, Pearson Prentice Hall. 2012. ISBN# 0-13-978-0-13-249267-6.

  - Why is it called the "gift of fire"?
    - Prometheus, according to Greek myth, gave the gift of fire to humans
      - According to anthropologists, this is what started our race: we used fire to: heat our homes, cook our food, and run the machines that we depend on.
      - But there were also disasters because of fire: the fires of Rome, the Chicago fire in 1871 left 100,000 people homeless, the fires of the oil fields of Kuwait were intentionally set ablaze, etc.
        - Fire was considered as the root of some of the most dangerous humanly created disasters for thousands of years.
    - Computer technology is the most significant new technology since the beginning of the Industrial Revolution:
      - it allowed us to control machines, communicate, travel to space, etc.
      - but it also creates powerful problems: potential loss of privacy, multimillion-dollar thefts, and breakdowns of large, complex systems that we depend on (e.g., air traffic control systems, communications networks, banking systems)

Please

- Please be on time
- Please show respect for your classmates
- Please turn off (or use vibrate for) your cellphones

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- On-topic questions are welcome

Composition of Grades

Composition of Grade	Percentage	Dates
Midterm	30%	Week 10
Fina Exam	30%	Week 19
Homework Assignments and Group Presentation	25%	TBD
Take-home online Quizzes	15%	TBD
Group Presentations		Week 16/17

Welcome
and Enjoy!